Saranga Thakura

Saranga (Sharnga) Thakura · @saranga-thakura

A Branch of Sri Chaitanya's Tree

Saranga Thakura was an associate (parshada) of Sri Gaura, one of those who shared His pastimes in Navadvipa. He is known by several names: Sarangadasa, Sharnga Thakura, Sharngapani and Sharngadhara.

Krishnadasa Kaviraja Gosvami, listing the branches of Sri Chaitanya's tree in the "Chaitanya-charitamrita," names him alongside Ramadasa, Kavidatta, Sri Gopaladasa and Bhagavatacharya:

"Ramdas, Kavidatta, Sri Gopal Das, Bhagavat Acharya, Thakura Sharanga Das." (CC, Adi 10.113)

Everyone named in this line is a prominent branch of the tree.

The "Bhakti-ratnakara" remembers him too. In the very opening blessings of the book, where Narahari Chakravarti glorifies the Lord's associates, we read: "Glory to Abhirama, Vamshi, Saranga and Sundara!" (BR 1.29), and in the second wave once more: "Glory to Sri Saranga and Abhirama, jewel of virtues!" (BR 2.15)

Bhajana on the Bank of the Ganga

Saranga Thakura lived on the bank of the Ganga in Modadruma-dvipa, one of the nine islands of Sri Navadvipa.[1] Each island of Navadvipa embodies one of the nine forms of devotional service, and Modadruma-dvipa is the island of dasya, service to the Lord. Today the village of Mamgachhi stands on this spot.

There, in seclusion by the river, Saranga spent his days remembering the Lord and chanting the holy names. This intimate bhajana gave him the power for which his deeds became famous: not worldly "magic," but the mercy of the Lord, which pours down upon one who is wholly devoted to Him.

The Vaishnavas have kept a special tradition about this power. The Sanskrit vandana attributed to Srila Jiva Gosvami says:

"I praise Sharnga Thakura, who revealed his greatness: he gave snakes places in his own dwelling." ("Vaishnava-vandana," 102)

And the Bengali tripadi vandana adds that "six score" — a hundred and twenty — snakes lived in his patched quilt (tripadi "Vaishnava-vandana," 89). One absorbed in the holy name knows no fear, and even snakes found shelter beside him.

The Vow and the Lord's Will

Saranga Thakura displayed the pastime of a supremely solitary bhajana. It is said that he vowed never to accept disciples, fearing that they would distract him from his service.

But Mahaprabhu had other plans for him. Sri Gaurasundara urged Saranga again and again to accept disciples, conveying His will to him more than once. According to the "Gaudiya-vaishnava-abhidhana," the Lord once met him on a street in Navadvipa — in the days when He was rebuking Devananda Pandita for his offence against Srivasa — and told him plainly to give up his vow.[2]

Thakura Murari

Saranga could not disobey the Lord. He resolved: “Whomever I meet first tomorrow morning, I will make my disciple and give him the mantra.” Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati Thakura also relates this tradition in his “Anubhashya.”

The next morning, as Saranga was bathing in the Ganga, the current carried a dead body to his feet — his foot even touched it. It was a youth who had died of snakebite. Following the custom of the time, his parents had not cremated the body but had laid it on a raft and set it adrift on the Ganga — so the “Abhidhana” tells.

Saranga took hold of the body and, as tradition tells, brought the dead youth back to life by the power with which the Lord had endowed him. He asked: “Who are you? What is your lineage (gotra)?” Slowly coming to himself, the youth saw a great soul before him and bowed at his feet. Naming his caste and family, he said: “My name is Murari. Be merciful to me!” Thus Saranga kept the word he had given the Lord: he accepted the youth and gave him mantra-diksha. This disciple became renowned as Sri Thakura Murari.

From then on the disciple’s name was joined to the teacher’s: Saranga came to be called Sharnga (Saranga) Murari, and he is called so to this day.[3]

A few days later Saranga taught his new disciple to serve his Deities, Sri Sri Radha-Gopinatha. The followers of Thakura Murari, generation after generation, now live in the village of Shar.[4]

Saranga Thakura himself, according to the “Abhidhana,” became an empowered preacher of Mahaprabhu’s dharma. Here lies the chief lesson of his life: he who sought solitude so that nothing might disturb his remembrance and chanting of the holy name became, by Mahaprabhu’s will, one who carried that name to others. The power gained in the stillness of the Ganga’s bank was offered in the Lord’s service.

The Deities and the Temple at Mamgachhi

The worship of the Deities of Radha-Gopinatha whom Saranga Thakura served continues at Mamgachhi to this day.[5]

The old temple was built beside a very ancient bakula tree; according to tradition, it has grown here since the time of Saranga Thakura himself. Some years ago a new temple building for the Deities of Sri Sharnga Murari was raised in front of the bakula tree; the temple is now in the care of the Gaudiya Math.

In the same temple Sri Madana-Gopala is also worshipped — the Deity served by another associate of Mahaprabhu, Vasudeva Datta Thakura. Pilgrims on the Navadvipa parikrama come here for darshan. Not far from the home of Sharnga Murari, at the birthplace of Vrindavana Dasa Thakura, Srila Bhaktisiddhanta Sarasvati founded a temple.

According to our calendar, on the adhivasa day of Gaura-purnima — Gaura-chaturdashi of the month of Govinda — the Navadvipa parikrama passes through Modadruma-dvipa: the birthplace of Vrindavana Dasa Thakura and the Deities of Sri Saranga Murari and Vasudeva Datta Thakura.

Appearance and Departure

Nothing is known of Saranga Thakura’s birth, family or years of life. According to one biography, he appeared on the krishna-chaturdashi of the month of Ashadha.[6]

His departure falls on the krishna-trayodashi of the month of Agrahayana. In our calendar this is the “Disappearance Day of Srila Sharanga Thakura” — krishna-trayodashi of the month of Keshava.

Nandimukhi

Who Saranga Thakura is in Krishna's eternal pastimes is revealed by Kavi Karnapura in the "Gaura-ganoddesha-dipika":

"Nandimukhi, who was in Vraja, is now Saranga Thakura. Some consider him Prahlada, but my father does not accept this." (GGD 172)

Thus in Vraja he is the gopi Nandimukhi, the sister of Madhumangala. Kavi Karnapura mentions the opinion that he is Prahlada, only to set it aside at once: his father, Shivananda Sena, does not hold this view.

1. According to the "Shripata-paryatana," Vamshivadana, Kavidatta and Saranga Thakura lived in the neighbouring villages of Kulia and Paharpur (later the town of Kulia-Paharpur, present-day Navadvipa, Koladvipa).

2. In the "Chaitanya-bhagavata" account of Devananda's rebuke (CB, Madhya 21) Saranga is not named.

3. According to one biography, "Thakura Murari, or sometimes Saranga Murari" are names of the disciple himself.

4. According to one biography, the descendants of Saranga's disciples live in the village of Shava ("corpse"); it is probably the same village.

5. According to one biography, he established the worship of Sri Sri Radha-Govinda.

6. According to another biography, the krishna-chaturdashi of Ashadha is an alternative opinion on the day of his departure.